



YOGTANTRAGAMA
ISSN NO: 2454-888X

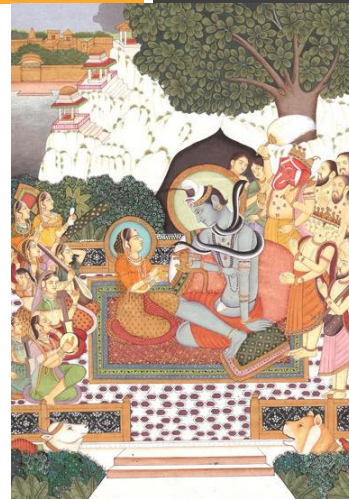


Oct- Dec 2018

From the Editor in Chief's desk:

By Swami Paranand Tirth

EDITOR IN CHIEF: SWAMI PARANAND TIRTH



<http://indianminiaturepaintings.blogspot.com/2011/05/shiva-and-shakti.htm>

Discarding conditioning for the word transcendence and a seat in one's essential nature .

There are various notions of conditionings which confine an aspirant to his conventional identity and impede his identification with his essential nature . Adepts of the yore have given

various renderings of the three conditionings which are the semiotic depictions of garments . Another meaning of the word *kanchuka* is an armor worn by ancient warriors to protect the fighter . All shambhav means are a posteriori of winning the spiritual battle which can be compared to shakta upaya where after the battle a warrior lays down his weapons and takes off

the armor to get seated in his essential nature . The battle is contingent and temporal and it does not have much to do with the essential nature but an aspirant must revert to grosser tactics if the lower nature is too demanding on him and marring his splendor and grandeur of shivahood . The discarding of *kanchuka* can be understood in either way . The three *kanchukas* viz *bhavika* or perceptual, *bhautika* or material ,*shunya* or devoid of all objectivity - have been explained in three different ways by Ananta shakti pada the illustrious commentator of *Vatul Nath Sutras*.

Perceptual or exterior portion of the phenomena which binds the consciousness is the objective awareness of the five perceptions of sound touch sight taste and smell ,ten senses mind reason and ego . These comprise the grosser bulk of the objective phenomena hence these are categorized as one of the three *kanchuka* . Another rendering of the word *kanchuka* called perceptual is external objects of perception like jar etc. yet another meaning is doodle or the dream state. The mental creation till the dream is over is as real as the material one owing to *bhavana* or arising from *bhavana* or mental imagery *bhavika* type of conditioning has been called as dream by the commentator, *swapna* is related to sustenance .

Bhautikam or material conditioning is also explained in three ways presumably to suit the competence or temperament of the aspirant. First rendering is for aspirants with a grosser world view and the term pertains to the grosser manifestations like the elements of earth etc. To the aspirant with a more mystic bent extraneous perceptions depend on a priori impressions in the mind projected through the senses so *bhautikam* is introvert perceptions through the sense organs . *Bhautikam* for an evolved aspirant is jagrat which in the context of agamas pertains to knowledge [*jnanam jagrat*] .This state is related to creation .

The third *kanchuka shunya* for an aspirant of superior competence is the “desire to remain desire less” the penultimate before transcending all desiring process which is incessant and other

wise hard to transcend . This “ desire to remain desire less” being a *kanchuka* must be discarded too. The medium or ether which mediates the objective external perceptions and the perceiver has been defined as *shunyam* by the commentator. For a more composed aspirant who has a considerable control over the functioning of his sense perceptions this is the third binding condition . *Sunyam* literally means a void, this as we have mentioned earlier must not be confused with the *shunya* of the Buddhism which means *niswabhavatwam* or senselessness owing to the apparent absence of all objectivity in the state of deep sleep. So the *shunyam* is the state devoid of all objectivity or sleep.

So an aspirant must analyze his position and decide the mode of *kanchukas* or limitations in his particular case, meditate on them and seek means of discarding them. Till one has discarded these *kanchuka* one remains within the domain of expressible word without a proper expression and the discipline of speech and one can not reach the spring board of word transcendence .Once this has been accomplished one can attain unison with one’s *nikhya* [unspoken] nature which is beyond all words and expressions . Anant shakti says *nirakhya* is the state of namelessness which is not just refraining from speech but transcending all four modes of speech or vak referred to in the next sutra. This word transcendent essential nature is also perse there is no deviation from this. The description, mode and method of discarding these *kanchukas* must come from a master. One might as well remain caught in the quagmire of words and expressions and never go beyond them if one went independently and arbitrarily about it .

Swami Paranand Tirth
Founder President & CEO
YTA Yoga Tantra and Agama (inc.)
Head
Yog Tantra et Agama centre (Montreal, Canada)

Editorial



Dr. Geetika Kaw Kher

To be in control of one's body and senses is desirable but what matters most is the ability to control one's mind which flutters like a bird and where thoughts backed with reason and ego keep cooking up stories which in turn lead to various thoughts and thought constructs.

The difficult question here is who should control the mind? Is the sense of self, which is essentially a product of many constructs since the day one is born the correct entry to judge? Such questions have intrigued scholars and mystics both who have tried to delve beyond conventions. Some of them have shared their revelations in form of aphorism, poems and commentaries but none of them can answer the questions for us. They can only take us to the well, drinking part we have to do ourselves since drinking from the fountain of wisdom is experiential knowledge and cannot be completely transmitted through the written word only.

Explaining the various forms of '*kanchukas*' conditionings or coverings our guru maharaj Swami Paranand Tirth ji in the editorial writes "An aspirant must analyze his position and decide the mode of *kanchukas* or limitations in his particular case, meditate on them and seek means of discarding them. Till one has discarded these *kanchuka* one remains within the domain of expressible word without a proper expression and the discipline of speech and one can not reach the spring board of word transcendence" Hence to go beyond one's

constructed self one needs to first identify and gradually work at the limitations which hide the splendor of one's essential nature.

Next we have Swamiji's enlightening article 'Wisdom from Shiva's Rattle drum' emphasizing the importance of Prithvi tattva in Nandikeshvara's Kashikas. The perception of smell is the main property of earth. The ancient world view is that we smell earth, taste water, see fire, touch air and hear ether. Five perception converge into the mind and the mind converges into reason and when the reason is in unison with its source of consciousness one is enlightened. All five properties of the respective elements merge into the fifth or the first, fifth from the divergent view point of creation and first from the convergent stand point of dissolution. The fifth one has been discussed separately since the earth contains all five properties and that accounts for its separate and independent disposition.

This is followed by Niraj Kumar's article on **Panchastavi and Abhinavagupta** where the author has proposed the idea that Panchastavi, the very popular hymn in Kashmir was probably composed by Abhinavagupta. Panchastavi, not only reveals the three fold-nature of the Universe and the three-letter seed mantra to seek divine grace, it is one of the sweetest and most beautiful composition that establishes absolute non-duality. It is a text which can be grasped by common man and still has hidden secrets that can lead philosophers on a quest. Panchastavi is the living proof of the Indian propensity to settle conflicting paradigms under the banner of Advaita. In the 32rd verse of the last canto, even Buddha and Jina Mahavira, are described as the different names by which righteous persons call the Goddess Tripura.

This is followed by some thought provoking poetic excerpts from the book "My Greece: Mirrors and Metamorphoses" by Ambika Talwar. Going beyond a general travelogue the book comes across as a metaphysical and spiritual quest where geography, biology and mythology coalesce in one whole.

WISDOM FROM SHIVA'S RATTLED DRUM लण् 6

Swami Paranand Tirth

Abstract – Though the last of the five elements a separate sutra had to be framed for its depiction . The earth comes across as the substratum, the sustaining principle and the upanisadic theory of procreation . Reasons for not being included in the preceding aphorism will be discussed . Some later grammarians formed their separate sutras and framed separate sutras inspired by Nadikeshwara's kashika and Upmanyus vritti on them . This serves as a prelude to the next aphorism and its meaning –the great tantric secret .

Key words: Kashika ,Annam,Pratyahar , Anubandh,

In the previous aphorism Nandikeshwar has stated the five fold manifestation of the universal phenomena but there are only four letters in the aphorism. This is to emphasise the importance of the fifth one I.e. *Prithvi* . The next aphorism has been attributed only to establish earth as the foundation of the four elements and for that matter that of the entire universe. Owing to its stability and solidarity the earth or the element of earth comprises the substratum of the entire sentient as well the insentient universe. The earth as the foundation of sentient portion of the phenomena has been supported by the author of these *karika*.

According to the dictum of the Upanishads food grain comes from earth as the water cycle of yajna causes rain and the rain water irrigates the fields whence food grain or *annam* is obtained . A person eats that *annam* which is why there is a saying that the *purusa* is made up of *annam* and *rasa* or food and fluids . All components of physical gross body come from the *annam* .The food or *Annam* partaken generates the seed which upon germinating leads to the procreation of all creatures belonging to the four genus I.e. congenitally wrapped in the placenta ,born from

eggs ,born from sweat ,and born from the earth * [called *jarayuj* ,*swedaja*,*andaja* and *udbhija*] The *Annam* food grain comes from the earth so the earth turns out to be the foundation of all. This specification of four categories follows an ancient version of reasoning in which the ontologies vary to befit the argument to be supported .The earth has the four attributes of all other four elements viz sound,touch,colour and taste including smell that is its own characteristic. These five attributes make earth a consolidate entity upon which all other elements along with their permuted and combined structures of the world are caricatured

आधारभूताजगतस्त्वमेका महीस्वरूपेणयतः

स्थितासि ।

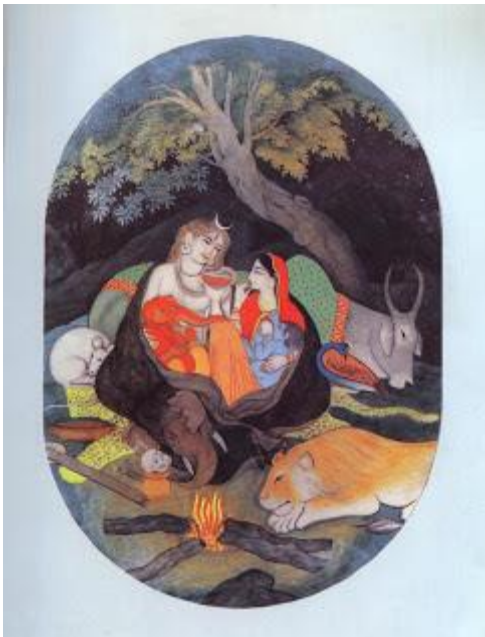
(Durga saptasati)

While felicitating the primordial nature the demigods say that you are the foundation substratum of this universe since you manifest as the earth or the element of earth. In indian logic there are two variants of earth, earth as an effect which manifests in the form of gross soil rocks, boulders etc.and the earth as the causation which manifests in its causal form which has been encrypted in this aphorism as the seed syllable *lam*.

The perception of smell is the main property of earth. The ancient world view is that we smell earth ,taste water ,see fire, touch air and hear ether . Five perception converge into the mind and the mind converges into reason and when the reason is in unison with its source of consciousness one is enlightened . Most of the ontological specifications serve the purpose of being conducive to the ultimate objective of human existence, the main characteristic of the earth . The earth as we will discuss in the consequent aphorism has all five properties pervading it thus this only one monosyllabic syllable serves as a link between the next one which encrypts all properties of the five fold matter in it,and the preceding one which describes the syllabic semiotics of the four elements, their seed syllables and their origin in

the rattledrum of lord *Shiva* –the first primordial master of all wisdom.

One recent grammarian named Budhisagar Suri however went independently about the sutras and devised his own sutra which synthesies *lan*, with preceding aphorism. This independence from the Panini's and Patanjali's orthodoxy indicates their bent towards atheistic and non vedic lore. Budhisagar Suri presumably a jain scholar inherited this trend from his predecessor Chandragomin a budhist. Both were the exponents of the theory of refuting revelation as the testimony of evidence and establishing that word doesn't have to be innately related to its meaning so his concept of synthesized sutra *ha ya va ra lanj*, though more consistent doesn't fall in with the mystic tradition of *Shiva* and Panini. Like some recent dogmas they never found it worthwhile to maintain the superhuman or divine origin of these aphorisms so such alterations were not considered blasphemous. Shaakatayan, another votary of Chandragomin also invented a new sutra *haya vara lanj*. Owing to the difference in anubandha or purport this may not mean exactly the same as Chandragomin and for that matter how Budhisagar Suri construed it.



<http://blog.artoflegendindia.com/2013/11/sons-of-shiva.html>

Nandikeshwara is believed to have existed in the second century AD, some maintain his time 2nd century BC. In either case he predates

Budhisagar Suri and Chandragomin and Shakatayan. Therefore there is every reason to believe that despite their non believer disposition they compiled their different pratyaharas and adapted their sutras accordingly as per the interpretation of the *sutras* in Nandikeshwara's *kashika*.

All five properties of their respective elements merge into the fifth or the first, fifth from the divergent view point of creation and first from the convergent stand point of dissolution. The fifth one has been discussed separately since the earth contains all five properties and that accounts for its separate and independent disposition. Besides being a great mystic Nandikeshwara was also an exponent of ancient dance and dramaturgy and a couple of compendium on visual art aesthetics are attributed to him. The five perceptions are of immense significance in ancient dance and drama which, need less to say was metaphysically oriented. The five vadyas, sushir, percussions, cymbals, string ghataam etc converge the universal phenomena into one point i.e. the stage and the actors are actually possessed by the role they are playing be it a mundane character or a legendary figure, an epical or mythological entity all are spontaneously invoked and as it were actually communicate with audience. There is no existence beyond the three time dimensions and five elementary constituents of the universal phenomena so there are no faction of time and substance that cannot be reproduced provided aesthetic performance has a sound metaphysical footing. These aphorisms were imparted to deserving aspirants after the dynamic dance of *Shiva* culminated into a still and placid trance of superconsciousness the *parameshwara* the *guru* of the *gurus* propagated these through the beats of his rattle drum. The adept masters, says Patanjali in his ingenious commentary on the aphorisms of descriptive grammar as Chomsky calls it can convey their wisdom through gestures, movements of the eyes, index, sign and body language etc. They are seers so the very process of seeing and showing can also

serve as a medium of communication and for that matter communion too.

The sound emanating from a mounted percussion has been categorized as *pashyanti*. It is pregnant with all that can be expressed as audible or readable and conceivable “word”. *Pashyanti* is the state of germination where word and meaning have just begun to separate like a seedling so this monosyllabic beat contains an entire gamut of metaphysical secrets encrypted in it. In traditional ritualism and asceticism this syllable is attributed to Ganesh as well as Indra as both in some way or another pertain to the live force or *prana*. Those who are committed to the theorem of eternity of the living word –must try meditating on the original sound of the beat of Shiva’s rattle drum instead of pronouncing them. A pronounced word doesn’t imbibe the virtue of being eternal but the eternally resonate word can be experienced after the inner cacophony of “black noise” subsides through yoga meditation or other mystic practices. One of the knacks of word transcendence given in Vijnana Bhairav is meditation on the time fraction preceding the pronunciation and termination of any arbitrary syllable, in the present context *lan*.

*Yasya kasyapi varnasya purvantau
anubhavayet shunyaya shunya bhutousau
Shunyakarah puman bhavaet .*

To enter the realm of absolute word transcendence and zero objective awareness one can go about transcending word alphabetically. In the tradition of Shankara’s monism all dialective and discursive expositions are meant for refuting the perspective that self realization can be had by intelligence. It rather follows transcending reason, the methods for transcending reason a secret of the tantras and agamas. Besides the school of thought in which reasoning culminates into a realization of the supra-mental entity there is another lineage of monism in which the metaphysical wisdom is propagated through the induction of *nirvikalpa* –“ideation less” induction of the ultimate experience. The meaning of the two

portions of the great dictum is induced into the novice through a process called *nirvikalpa vakyartha* [the ideation less reproduction of the meaning of the two portions of the *mahavakyam*]. This is where scholastic and dialectical *Vedanta* differs from the actual experience of self realization. The main objective of these aphorisms aka beat from Shiva’s rattle drum was metaphysical completion, the purity of speech and refinement of Vak followed *en passant*.



Panchastavi and Abhinavagupta

Niraj Kumar

Panchastavi is a collection of five devotional hymns. The first is the *Laghustava* which is the shortest one and contains 21 verses. Next is the *Charchastava* with 31 verses, *Ghatastava* with 24 verses, *Ambastava* with 32 verses and the last one *Sakal-janani-stava* is the longest comprising 38 verses. It is a prasashati poem(panegyric) to the Goddess *Tripura Sundari*. *Panchastavi* has been popular among Kashmiris Pandits . It is more than a thousand years old.

According to Janakinath Kaul Kamal, the earliest extant reference to verses of *Panchastavi* are found in the *Saraswatikanthabharana* of King Bhoja, who ruled from Ujjain, Malwa (1010 to 1060 A.D.). The probable date of the composition of *Saraswatikanthabharan* is between 1030-1040 A. D. *Saraswatikanthabharanam* is a work on Poetics in which King Bhoja compiled wide range of human experience and knowledge and discussed the poetics in details to lay down the rules of poetic composition to maximize the aesthetic delight. Many believe that *Panchastavi* must have been composed much earlier to it, for during those times it took years for ideas to travel and get popular to be noticed. Most pit its origin sometimes between the *Saundarya-Lahiri*, which was composed by *Samkaracharya*(788-820 A.D.) and the notice taken by Bhoja. *Saundarya Lahiri* appears to be the inspiration for the devotional hymns in *Panchastavi*, with the Goddess *Tripura Sundari* as the pole .

While great commentator on *Tantra* treatises, *Lakshmidhara* claims that *Panchastavi* was composed by *Kalidas* ,possibly noticing how the text finds earliest mention in the works of Bhoja, both belonging to Ujjain; some like Pandit Natharam Sastri plead for Abhinavagupta (950-1020 A.D.), a contemporary of King Bhoja. Some attribute it's authorship to Adi Shankaracharya, while many to Dharmacharya from Kashmir. Janaki Nath Kaul Kamal and Laxman Joo Maharaj put their weight behind Dharmacharya, since *Laxmidhara* who includes the *Panchastavi* text in his commentary upon *Saundarya Lahiri* refers to the author as Dharmacharya. Nityananda, another commentator on *Tantra* mentions the name of Dharmacharya as the composer of *Laghustava*. Vidyaranya, mentions about Dharmacharya and *Laghustava* in his work, *Srividya-mavatanttra*(Chapter 31). Vidyaranya was the high priest of Harihar and Bukka Raya, who founded Vijayanagar empire and propagated the *Srividya* tradition. He wrote a treatise, *Sarva-darshana-sangraha* in which a chapter was devoted to *Pratyabhijna* thought from Kashmir. His engagement with thought-currents from Kashmir would have acquainted him with Abhinavagupta's work in greater measure.

Madhva-Vidyaranya, who became 12th Shankaracharya at Sringeri mentions about the encounter between Adi Shankaracharya and Abhinavagupta in "*Shankar-Digvijaya*", which clearly is figment of his imagination since the two great Saivite scholars were not contemporary and lived centuries apart. Local tradition of attributing origin of *Panchastavi* either to Shankaracharya or to Abhinavagupta appears from the story of this imaginary encounter.

Mammata, the great commentator on poetics profusely quotes the *Panchastavi* verses in his *Kavya Prakash*(12th century) text. It is amply

clear that thinkers on poetics like Bhoja and Mammata were quite conversant with the *Panchastavi*. This can be possible if we put up the authorship of Abhinavagupta to the *Panchastavi*. Abhinavagupta was a great synthesizer of tantras and aesthetic theories. His influence on subsequent generation of thinkers on poetics had been immense. Thus, even if the text might not have been popular with the people at large, this would have reached the hands of thinkers on poetics at the earliest. Secondly, local stories are not merely byproduct of imagination. Exaggerations do creep up, but the cultural memories are grounded in some event of gigantic proportion. It appears that one of the Shankaracharya might have visited Kashmir during Abhinavagupta time. The author of *Sankar-Digvijaya* mixed the different stories of Shankaracharyas' travels into Kashmir.

Abhinavagupta wrote five hymns to Shiva towards the end of his life. The *Parmarthcharcha* viz. "Inquiry into Ultimate Reality" (There is a corresponding *Charchastava* (IInd stava) in *Panchastavi*), *Mahopadeshvimastika*, *Dehastha-devatachakra-strota* (Eulogy on the wheels of divinities existing in the bodies); *Bhairavastava* (Eulogy on the Absolute Reality) and *Anubhavanivedana* (The Offering of the Direct Experience of the reality). The last one is devoted to the *bhairavi-mudra*, the attitude of the mystic who has found his own self. This has resonance in the *Panchastavi* also.

Even in his lifetime, Abhinavagupta was eulogized by his disciples. Madhuraja, a yogi from south, wrote *Gurunatha-paramarsha* where AG is described as avatar of Shiva. Abhinavagupta's popularity crossed the Vindhyas during his own life-time and Ujjain being a creative cultural centre would have pounced upon his great composition at the earliest. Bhoja rewarded a Pandit Purantaka, a worshipper in the temple of Mahakali for a poem *Shyamaldandaka*, a poem eulogizing

Sarasvati, in 1001. (Jane Gonda, p.259) Five decades is quite a long time for Abhinavagupta's short beautiful poetic composition to reach in the hands of a polyglot like Bhoja, who had fondness with the *shringar rasa* in literature.

Prof. K.N.Dhar mentions that in various manuscripts in the Kashmir Government Research Library, the name of Acharya Prithvi Dhara, a disciple of Shambhunath (Guru of Acharya Abhinavagupta) finds mention as the author. Many texts mention about Kalidas. And most agree that it is one Dharmacharya. Dharmacharya, Prithvi Dhara and even Kalidas are merely assumed names. The worshipper of Mahakali were also termed Kalidas. Bhoj rewarded a Pandit Purantaka, known also as Kalidas in 1001 A.D. for his composition. Since the composer of *Panchastavi* eulogizes the Goddess in her red as well as dark complexion unlike *Srividya* texts from the South, it is assumed that the poet was Kali-worshipper. We already know that Tara worship was quite popular among both Buddhist and Hindus by the time Abhinavagupta came onto literary scene of India. In the very first canto, *Laghustava*, name Tara along with Jaya, Laxmi and Tripura has been mentioned (*Laghustava: verse. 18*). Verse 13 and 37 of the fifth canto, *Sakal-janani-stava* is dedicated to the dark coloured form of the Goddess. Thus, the appearance of the name of Kalidas is in no way contradictory to the Kashmiri belief about composition of *Panchastavi* by Abhinavagupta, since Abhinava was a great Kaula sadhak and wrote extensively on the rituals in the cremation ground. Kali is also the *ishta-devi* of Kashmiri tantriks. Dharmacharya itself is a honorific and a great mystic-thinker like Abhinavagupta would surely have held many other honorifics. Moreover, history records Abhinavagupta as the worthy disciple of Shambhunath. There is no confusion once Abhinavagupta is credited with the masterly work, since that also bridges the divide between popular perception and scholarly references.

Dr. B.N.Pandit argues for the domicile of Dharmacharya in Kerala. He has different point of view that *Panchastavi* resembles *Saundaryalahiri* of Shankaracharya in technique and content, that it alludes to *Sabri* as the form of the Goddess. *Sabri* holds an important position in tantrik tradition of Kerala (Sabarimala is one of the most sacred sites in India), that the hymns does not mention about *Trika* or *Kaula Yoga* popular in Kashmir but alludes highest importance to *Kundalini*. Dr. Pandit has missed the essential points. Tara is not worshipped in Kerala tradition or southern tradition. It is a north Indian deity that spread further northward across the Himalayas. Southern tradition worship Supreme Goddess in the form of fair complexion. Shaivism in the south India is predominantly dualistic. *Panchastavi* posits absolute non-duality and it is unlikely that it would have been composed in the south and gained popularity at Ujjain and Kashmir at the same time. There is also mention about *Vatuk Bhairava* (Charchastava:29), who was popular deity in Kashmir and not Kerala.

The references made in the hymns about snow, pomegranate, blue lotus and herbs like *trupsi* and *priyangu* establishes further the Kashmiri origin of the composition. In the verse 14 of the last *stava*, the mention of Goddess form of *Kundalini* appearing dark as *Priyangu* is an important mark that indicates the proof.

प्रियङ्गुश्यामाङ्गीमिरुषतरवातः किसलयं
समुन्मीलन्मुक्ताफलबहुलनेपथ्यकुसुमम्।
स्तनद्वन्द्वस्फारस्तबकनमितां करुणलतिकां सकृद्व्यायन्तस्त्वां
वधति शिबघ्नन्ता मणिपदम् ॥१४॥

(Those (devotees) who meditate constantly on Thee with Thy limbs dark-blue in color, like the *Priyunga* creeper, dressed in red, resembling its (unopened) buds, and Thy form bent with (the weight of) Thy two voluminous breasts, (bulging

out) like massive bunches of its Pearl-like fruit, adorned with fully blossomed flowers, the bestower of all desires, like the wish-fulfilling creeper, they (those devotees, O Goddess) attain to the *Chintamani* state (all-desires-fulfilling gem) of Shiva Consciousness.)

(trans. Gopi Krishna, 1975)

Priyangu (*Callicarpa macrophylla*) literally means that which is lovable or charming. It is one of the herbs mentioned in ancient scriptures of Ayurveda. Its synonyms are derived from the common etymological root, *Priya*, like *phalapriya*, *priya*, *priyavalli*. Other synonyms are *streyasa*, *syaama*, *subhaga*, *nandini*, *mangalya*. There is a belief that *Priyangu* puts forth blossom only when a woman touches it. This establishes a direct connection of the form of Shakti and the *Priyangu*. Its fruit are dark blue that represents infinite consciousness in experiential (anubhava) spirituality. The plant grows only in the South Himalayan belt from Kashmir to Bengal and Assam. Then, there is mention of another creeper *trapushi* (*Laghuvastava*.II). *Janakinath Kamal* mentions that *trapusi* is a kind of fern whose first sprout is tender and beautiful and resembles the rising *Kundalini*. In Kashmir, it is locally known as “gyavthir”. Though, *trapushi* is also the Sanskrit name for cucumber. This makes it abundantly clear that it is unlikely that *Panchastavi* would have been composed in Kerala.

The most important hint at *Abhinavagupta*, himself being the composer of the *Panchastavi* is the use of *tribija*- aim, *klim* and *sauh*. We know how *Abhinavagupta* himself established *bija* “*Sauh*” as the heart of *Bhairava* in *Para-Trisika-Vivarana* (verse 9-16). Generally, the three *bijas* used in the Goddess worship are ‘aim’, *klim*, *hrim*, signifying the three aspects of goddess: *jnana*, *kriya* and *iccha* (wisdom, action and will). The three great goddess, *Mahasaraswati*, *Mahalaxmi*, *Mahakali* are the primary manifestation of the *Para-shakti*, *Tripura*. The Goddess is also known as *Hrimkari* (*Laghustava*:18). But, the substitution

of the “hrim” bija with the “Sauh” bija could not have been done before Abhinavagupta. It is only Abhinavagupta who established “sauh” as the amrit-bija, the seed of immortality.

Abhinavagupta mentions that one who is not born of Yogini or united with Rudra cannot comprehend this supreme seed. This is the hradaya-bija of the Param-Shiva, and confers liberation. Thus, “sauh” representing the Mahakali form of the Goddess Tripura substituting ‘hrim’ brings in valuable resolution between Monistic Shaivism and the Shaktism in Kashmir. This could have been done only by a person of stature like Abhinavagupta.

Importantly, Abhinavagupta wrote pentad for Shiva. He is the progenitor of the idea of bimba-pratibimba. The subtle to grosser manifestation operates like the mirror-image. In this theory, reflection is not identical, but one in which there is separate form, like triangle and inverted triangle, thereby having same structure in different form. It is the eternal recursion of the characteristics. The existence itself becomes a mosaic fractal. There is difference in sameness, and then recurrence of earlier forms. Thus, a pentad for Shiva must be followed by pentad of Shakti.

We also find extensive use of imagery of bimba-pratibimba in Panchastavi. Kundalini is described as the coiled tendril of the creeper plants. Kundalini is further described as the lightning creeper, the endless bifurcation in the lightning(tadi). It is this establishment of his own principle and attempt to resolve the divide that Panchastavi mentions about shata-chakra(6-chakras) and kundalini as piercing the shatachakra by the grace of the Goddess. Shatachakra brings coherence to the picture of bimba-pratibimba. The Shiva-triangle and its mirror image, an inverted shakti triangle interlocks to form a shatachakra. It is to bring coherence in the whole system that “sauh” became more apt as a bija than “hrim”, though hrim with curved “ha” is used to represent

coiled kundalini. The three bijas is the best way to offer salutation to the Tripura.

ऐन्द्रस्येव शरासनस्य वधती मध्ये ललाटं प्रभां
शोक्लीं कान्तिमनुष्मगोरिष शिरस्थातन्वती सर्वतः।
एषासौ त्रिपुरा हृदि क्षुतिरिवोष्मांशोः सबाहः स्थिता
छिन्नाम्रः सहसा पदैस्त्रिभिरघं ज्योतिर्मयी वाङ्मयी ॥११॥

(May the Goddess Tripura, who is of the nature of light and sound, shining in the forehead like the lustrous bow of Indra (i.e. the rainbow) in the crown of the head like the luminous white shine of the moon, and in the heart like the never-setting splendorous sun — may She, by means of the three mighty syllables 'Aim', 'Klim', and 'Sauh', speedily destroy all our impurities.)

((trans. Gopi Krishna, 1975)

All three bijas themselves contain trines. Letter “Ai” in the bijamantra, Aim, has triangular space. Letter Ka in the bijamantra “klim” written in old devnagari or Bengali shows a triangle in the left. The crooked portion on the right resembles like a goad which represent Kundalini. The empty space is the Yonimandala which is the seat of Tripurasundari. In the Sharda script, Ka is written in the same way. The third letter “sauh” has the fourteenth vowel, “au” which appears like trident. Thus the three bija-mantras with which the pentad Panchastavi begins, itself represents picturesque view of the triadic nature of Existence. This might be seen as extension of chitrakavya to emphasis adulation to the divinity making it to be taken notice of by Bhoja who formulated rules for chitra-kavya.

The bimba-pratibimba aspect has appeared in various simile used by the composer. Kundalini resembles lightning and is also of the form of lightning. The most important aspect in the Panchastavi is the narration of effect of divine grace upon a bhakta. This could have been described so succinctly by Abhinavagupta only. Abhinavagupta describes in Tantraloka

(ChapterV-30-31) the seven blisses produced after penetration of cakras. In the stage of ‘parananda’(supremejoy), the body is motionless, with eyes closed for breath having pierced the talu(palate) where it whirls continuously producing tears of love and yawning. Tantraloka describes ten successive states towards attaining Sivahood-trembling, revolving, whirling, flight, stability, light, and bliss, vision, wonder and indescribable ecstasy of being settled in the Supreme self. In the fourth stava, Ambastava of the Panchastavi, the state of realization of divinity is described:

आविर्भवत्पुलकसन्ततिभिः शरीरै-
निष्पन्दमानसलिलैर्नयनैश्च नित्यम्।
वाग्भिश्च गद्गदपदाभिरुपासते ये
पादौ तवाम्ब भुवनेषु त एव धन्याः ॥४॥

O Mother, with hairs on their bodies standing on end, with tears streaming down from their eyes and with their voices quivering with emotion, those (devotees) who ceaselessly worship Thy feet in their heart, they are, indeed, blessed.

आनन्दलक्षणमनाहतनाम्नि देशे
नादात्मना परिणतं तव रूपमीशे।
प्रत्यङ्मुखेन मनसा परिधीयमानं
शंसन्ति नेत्रसलिलैः पुलकैश्च धन्याः ॥१९॥

*O Empress of the World: Those blessed ones who inwardly experience Thy blissful aspect at the place known as Anahata (heart chakra) in the form of Nada (Cosmic sound — the source of all speech) express the ecstasy of this encounter with their hair standing on end (through the intensity of emotion) and tears (of joy) pouring from their eyes.
(trans. Gopi Krishna, 1975)*

Thus, standing of hair on roots(pulakan) and tears of joy are the manifest expression of

delight when the shakti touches the heart of the devotee. It is the ‘touch’ which mediates between the immanence and transcendence. Skin/Touch(tvak) is both a gem and sensory organ. Body is considered the island of nine gems. These are seven dhatus namely-rasa(chyle), mansa(flesh), rudhira(blood), shukra(semen), majja(bone marrow), asthi(bone), meda(fat); and roma(hair) and tvak(skin/touch).

These are produced by body and grows on food. Touch appears to be unique because without it the sense organs can not experience. Sparsha pervades all other sense. Hence, it is most primordial. The corresponding body organ for sparsha is skin and the same is called ‘sparshana’. Thus, whenever the organ of touch, skin, bears some change; it is assumed that the body has been touched. If there is no external stimulus, the practitioners believed that they have been internally Touched, antahsparsh. It is the touch over the skin that causes hair to stand on roots. Thus, sparsha is the paramount sense in the tantras.

Panchastavi’s very second verse in Laghustava exhort this sense of touch:

या मात्रा त्रपुसीलतातनुससलनृत्तियसिस्पर्धिनी
वाग्बीजे प्रथमे स्थिता तव सदा सा मन्महे ते वयम्।
शक्तिः कुण्डलिनीति विश्वजनन्यतावारब्धोद्यमा
मात्वेत्थं न पुनःस्पृशन्ति जननीगर्भेऽर्भकस्य नराः ॥२॥

*We, Thy devotees, always meditate upon the vowel in Thy first syllable (Aim) resembling the fine first shoot of maiden-hair (a kind of fern) just beginning to sprout which itself is of the shape of Kundalini always engaged in the work of creation (of the universe). Realizing Thee in this form, man does not touch the womb of a mother again (i.e. is not reborn in this world).
(trans. Gopi Krishna, 1975)*

The allegory of trapushi creeper itself reflects the bimba-pratibimba in operation. Trapushi creepers are covered in fine white hairs, appearing to be standing like pulkan. As stated

earlier, the opening of the coiled tendril appear as unfolding of Kundalini. Similarly, we find mention of another plant, Priyangu. These bear dark blue seeds, but all over the petals and the stems, the white hairs appear as pulkan. There is belief that only when a woman touches the plant, it flowers. Thus, touch, standing hair, creeper, coiling everything that is associated with esoteric kundalini has allegoric presence in priyangu.

Panchastavi is compilation of hymns to Goddess, Tripura Sundari. The composer has described Tripura as the goddess who resides in Three places in the very first verse. She is of the nature of light(jyotirmayi) and sound(vangamayi), who shines in the forehead(lalat) like the lustrous bow of Indra (the rainbow); in the crown of the head like the luminous white shine of the moon, and in the heart like the sun. As sound ‘aim’, it resides in the forehead, as “klim” in the crown of the head and as “sauh” in the heart.

ऐन्द्रस्येव शरासनस्य दधती मध्ये ससाटं प्रभां
शौक्ली कान्तिमनुष्मागोरिब शिरस्थातन्वती सर्वतः।
एषासी त्रिपुरा हृदि क्षुतिरिबोष्मांशोः सदाहः स्थिता
छिन्नाम्रः सहसा पदैस्त्रिभिरधं ज्योतिर्नयी वाङ्मयी ॥१॥

In the verse 16 of the Laghustava, the composer explains the triple nature of the Existence in detail. There are three devas (Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva), three Vedas (Rig, Sam, Yajur), three fires (grihapatyahousehold, ahvaniyasacrificial, daks hinagni / crematory), the three Shaktis (desire/iccha, knowledge/jnana and action/kriya), the three sounds (uddat/ tenor, anuddat/ low, svarita/ medium), the three worlds (bhu, bhuvah, svah), the three-syllabled Gayatri (a,u,m), junction of three rivers (Ganga, Jamuna and Saraswati), the three Brahmas (Om, Tat, sat), and the three castes (Brahmin, Kshatriya and Vaisha). The poet declares that

all these and others that are modeled in three ways (i.e. which are threefold in nature), truly follow in trika- principle that flows from the Gooddness Tripura. Thus, the composer has sang in praise of the Kundalini having three-coils (Sakaljanistava:29), and the three deep lines marking the body of the Goddess (Laghustava:11). There are triple symbolism of Pujasamketa (secret of worship), Chakrasamketa (secret of chakra) and Mantrasamketa (secret of mantra) throughout the text. In the hymns, the Tripura Sundari is shown in three aspects- sthula (gross), sukshma (subtle), para (transcendental). Thus, ritual is also of three kinds- kayika (body), vachika (speech), Manasa (mind) or Bahayaga, Antaryaga and Bhavana. In the Laghustava, the mantra as the sound aspect and various dazzling objects as light aspect are described. This is the Bahayaga. In the second hymn, light as the inner contemplation aspect is provided. The third is the bhavana aspect— bhakti. In the Fourth canto, the experience and prayers to the Goddess in the form of kundalini has been described. In the fifth canto, there is the description of the Cosmic Mother, the shatachakra and their identity/correlation

वैशाना त्रितयं त्रयी हुतभुजां शक्तित्रयं त्रिस्वरा-
स्त्रैलोक्यं त्रिपदी त्रिपुष्करमथो त्रिब्रह्म वर्णास्त्रयः।
यत्किञ्चिज्जगति त्रिधा नियमितं वस्तु त्रिवर्गात्मकं
तत्सर्वं त्रिपुरेति नाम भगवत्यन्वेति ते तत्त्वतः ॥१६॥

Even the seedmantra, “aim klim sauh” has been chosen to complete the triple symbolism. One would have expected that once Samakaracharya’s Saundarya Lahiri was already extant which had explored on the panchakshari and shodashskahsari seed mantra for seeking blessing of Tripurasundari, further treatises on Goddess Tripura would continue with the syllabic formula. I have already discussed that only an authority like Abhinavagupta would have substituted “hrim” with para-bija of Trika shaivism, “sauh”. But, again this requires the genius and authority of an Abhinavagupta to bring in a trikakshari replacing extant verses, to

bring in more coherence of Trika Shaivism and Tripura Shaktism.

One is tempted to ask why pentad? Why did the poet not compose a triadic hymn to bring more coherence? Again this has to do with the fusion of Trika Shaivism with Tripura Shaktism. There are five main powers of Param Shiva viz. cit(consciousness), ananda(bliss), iccha(will), jnana(wisdom) and kriya(activity) as described in Para-Trisika-Vivarana. Similarly, there are five-fold acts – srishti(manifestation), sthiti(maintenance), samhara(absorption), vilaya(veiling) and anugraha(revelation). Composing a pentad for triadic Tripura brings the complete fusion of two paths.

Panchastavi, not only reveals the three fold-nature of the Universe and the three-letter seed mantra to seek divine grace, it is one of the sweetest and most beautiful composition that establishes absolute non-duality. It is a text which can be grasped by common man and still has hidden secrets that can lead philosophers on a quest. Panchastavi is the living proof of the Indian propensity to settle conflicting paradigms under the banner of Advaita. In the 32rd verse of the last canto, even Buddha and Jina Mahavira, are described as the different names by which righteous persons call the Goddess Tripura.

विद्युर्विष्णुर्ब्रह्मा प्रकृतिरणुरात्मा दिनकरः
स्वभावो जैनेन्द्रः सुगतमुनिराकाशमनिलः।
शिखः शक्तिश्चेति श्रुतिविषयतां तामुपगतां
विकल्पैरेभिस्त्वामभिदधति सन्तो भगवतीम् ।। ३३ ।।

(Thou are Brahma (the Creator), Vishnu (the Preserver) and Thou art matter, the embodied Soul, ego-consciousness, the Moon, the Sun, Nature (of things), the Lord of Jains (Mahavira), the illumined sage (Buddha), sky, air, also Shiva and Shakti. By these different names, O Goddess, Thou art heard of and called by the righteous.)

((trans. Gopi Krishna, 1975)

What an excellent thought that sprout from the land of Kashmir to propel the unity in plurality of Indian civilization!

(Niraj Kumar is the student of Nalanada Tradition. His forthcoming work is on Nalanda Tradition)

Refereneces:

1. Janakinath Kaul Kamal: Panchastavi: the pentad of hymns of Kundalini Yoga, Sri Ramakrishna Ashrama, Srinagar, 2001
2. Gopi Krishna: Panchastavi: A pentad of devotional hymns to Super-energy, Central Institute of Kundalini Research, 1975
3. Swami Laxmi Joo Maharaj(trans. from Sanskrit to Hindi).: Sri Panchastav, Dharmacharya-krit, February, 1974
4. Gopi Krishna: Ancient Secrets of Kundalini(Hidden in Panchastavi), 1995
5. Jaideva Singh: -Para-Trisika-Vivarana of Abhinvagupta, 1988
6. Jane Gonda: A History of Indian literature: Epics and Sanskrit Religious literature, 1977
7. Dr. B.N.Pandit: Panchastavi in Kashmir downloaded from ikashmir.net/panchastavi/article2.html
8. Prof. K.N.Dhar: Panchastavi-A Brief study downloaded from ikashmir.net/panchastavi/article1.html
9. Dr. Shiva Shankar Awasthi: Mantra aur Matrkaon ka Rahaasya, Chowkhamba, 1966

Some thought provoking excerpts from the book “My Greece: Mirrors and Metamorphoses” by

Ambika Talwar



An Indian mystic noted that people spend so much time, energy, patience , skill working hard to go to the moon, but he can go there in an instant and return. This is more than astral travel....

Let me swallow the moon

To share with you

Supernal light...

Let me sing a tune

Or two and see a rose

At edge of night

How she might glance

This passing moon

Goldenish trail

Kiss of delight...

Le me simply be ensconced

In a bed of red-hued rose petals

Sip rose mulled

In camphor wine

Alchemy of Center

Centers keep shifting

There are many levels of Being and Nothingness-

There is no one real feeling or state or ecstasy

I am a conglomerate of conflicting emotions, layers upon layers upon windowed layers:

Soul, forces lights shadows metaphors

I am tradition, home, joy...I am pathos.

I am sometimes awnings of meaninglessness

From whence do I come, but from home

Eternal and sometimes ungraspable?

I am space and spaces, treetops, tree fall, rainbows, darkness;

I am my own shelter, my caves, my eaves.

I steal myself from my Self- return myself to light

I too, am a child of god-light divine.

I am joys, love, eternal love, eternally!

When I fall, I am reminded that all I have to share with the world is Love.

This center

This love transcends both pain and pleasure

Nothing else is!

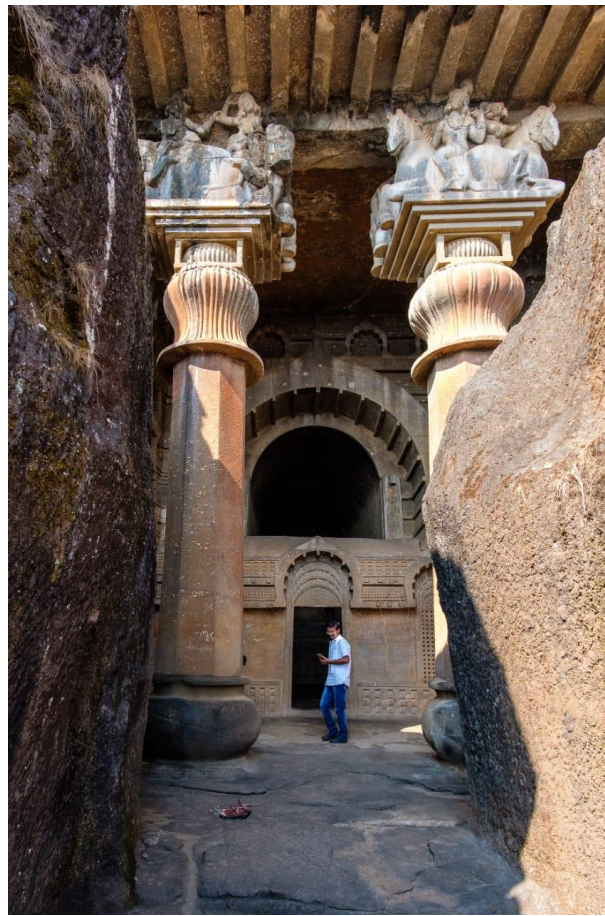
(Ambika Talwar is an author, healer, teacher and an artist and is currently teaching English in Cypress College)

Photo Essay on rockcut caves : Bedse, Bhaja and Karle

Dr. Geetika Kaw Kher

Rock cut architecture has fascinated me since my early college days. I very well remember being totally mesmerized to see the larger than life sculptures of lord Shiva at Elephanta caves: my first exposure to this art form. In the same study tour we were also taken to Bedse, Bhaja and Karle and introduced to early Buddhist rock cut architecture and studied its evolution in subsequent tours.

So after nineteen years when my brother and father proposed a visit to these caves, I could not hold my excitement . Since these caves are quite near Pune (45kms) and very close to each other we decided to visit them all in one day. Our first halt was at Bedse caves. The exterior takes the form of a massive part carved out of the rock face and serving as a kind of vestibule to the arcaded screen in its rear. It is composed of two columns between pilasters and it is guarded by the masses of rock left on either side . The design and execution of the pillars and pilasters of the portico make the facade a remarkable structure.



With rock cut structures it is the interiors that makes one marvel at the imagination and skill of the architects and artisans who could visualize and execute such designs in solid rock. While the chaitya griha (with a stupa inside) were meant for worship, viharas served as places where monks resided.



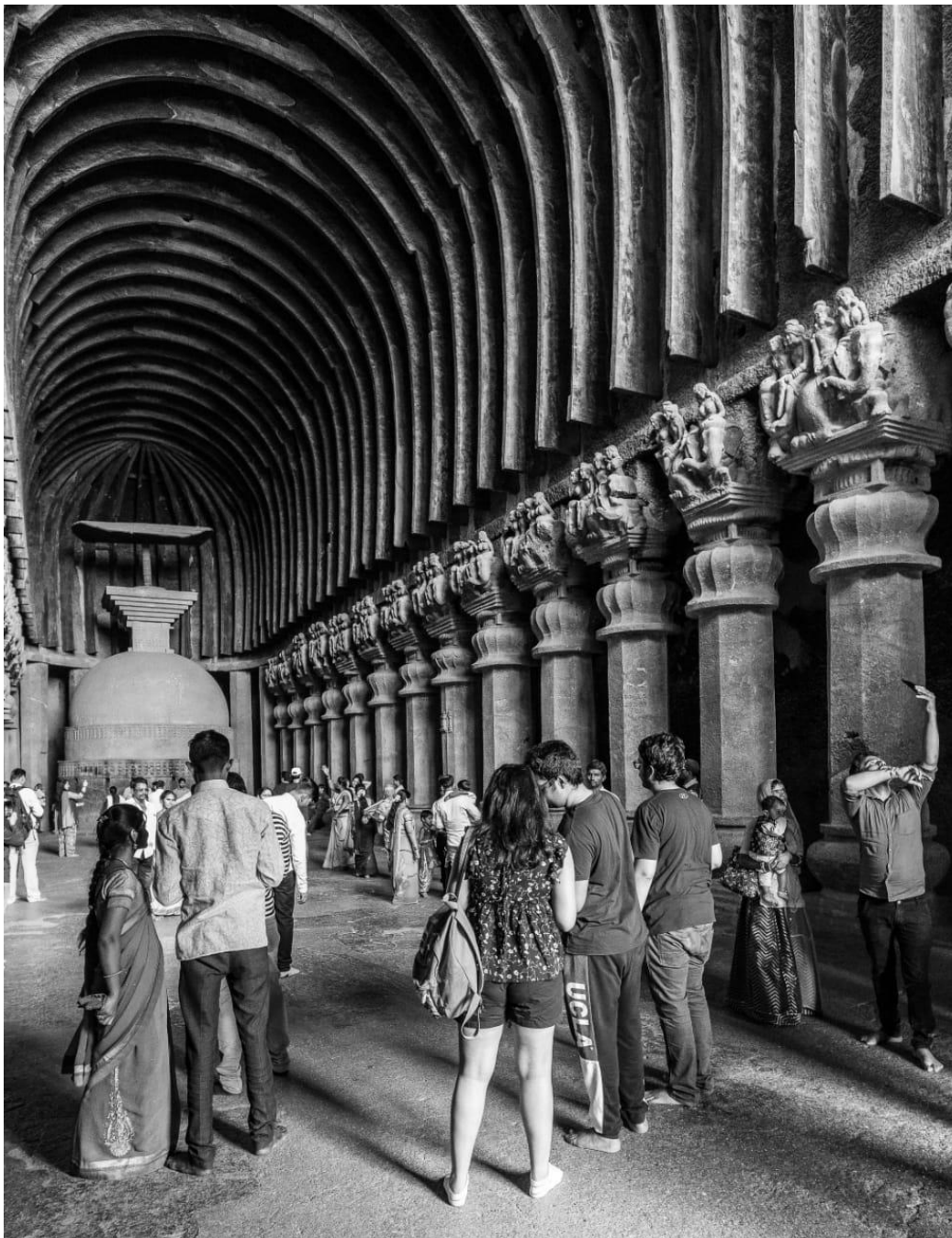
We next went to the oldest of these three complexes; Bhaja. It is datable to somewhere around 2nd C BC. The entrance has an open archway, bringing the entire interior of the hall into view unlike the earlier cave.





The meditative and serene feel of these caves is accentuated by the beautiful landscape surrounding them. A short easy climb leads one to these magnificent monuments which interestingly are hidden from the eyesight till one reaches the last leg.

The third cave at Karle is more frequented mainly because of the temple to goddess Ekavira by its side. The whole path was filled with shops and shopkeepers selling various puja items and other souvenirs. The tranquility felt at the other two sites was kind of missing here as it has been completely commercialized but that definitely does not take away the grandeur of Karle which meets ones eyes as soon as one manages to enter the main cave.





Overall the trip proved to be a nostalgic one with me remembering the events of nineteen years back , trying to recall what where my thoughts back then and how different are they now!



YOGTANTRAGAMA
ISSN NO: 2454-888X



Published by : Rashneek Kher, 901-902, Iris
Tower, Faridabad, Haryana, 121010 for YTA
Inc.

E-mail: swamiparanand@gmail.com

Logo: Manik Chawla

